

PREPARING FOR THE WORK

Blue denotes power point slide

Brown denotes instructions to technician

TEXT: [Nehemiah 2:11-20](#) (NKJV) *"So I came to Jerusalem and was there three days. (12) Then I arose in the night, I and a few men with me; I told no one what my God had put in my heart to do at Jerusalem; nor was there any animal with me, except the one on which I rode. (13) And I went out by night through the Valley Gate to the Serpent Well and the Refuse Gate, and viewed the walls of Jerusalem which were broken down and its gates which were burned with fire. (14) Then I went on to the Fountain Gate and to the King's Pool, but there was no room for the animal under me to pass. (15) So I went up in the night by the valley, and viewed the wall; then I turned back and entered by the Valley Gate, and so returned. (16) And the officials did not know where I had gone or what I had done; I had not yet told the Jews, the priests, the nobles, the officials, or the others who did the work. (17) Then I said to them, "You see the distress that we are in, how Jerusalem lies waste, and its gates are burned with fire. Come and let us build the wall of Jerusalem, that we may no longer be a reproach." (18) And I told them of the hand of my God which had been good upon me, and also of the king's words that he had spoken to me. So they said, "Let us rise up and build." Then they set their hands to this good work. (19) But when Sanballat the Horonite, Tobiah the Ammonite official, and Geshem the Arab heard*

of it, they laughed at us and despised us, and said, "What is this thing that you are doing? Will you rebel against the king?" (20) So I answered them, and said to them, "The God of heaven Himself will prosper us; therefore we His servants will arise and build, but you have no heritage or right or memorial in Jerusalem."

INTRO: There are times in history when a person or a group of people achieve accomplishments which are so extraordinary that it is almost impossible to erase their actions from our memories.

Unforgettable people and events would include:

(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Christopher Columbus and his willingness to go beyond the map to discover new lands...
- George Washington and his contribution to American history...
- Abraham Lincoln and his steadfast determination to emancipate the slaves in America...
- The Wright brothers and their contribution to aviation...
- Alexander Graham Bell and his role in developing the telephone...
- Thomas Edison and his invention of the light bulb...
- Henry Ford and his gift of the (Horse-less Carriage) the automobile...
- Martin Luther King and his sacrifices for civil rights...

- Mother Teresa and her benevolent generous contribution to the plight of under privileged human beings...
- Al Gore and his invention of the internet???!!!

These people have, in the truest sense of the word, left their footprints on the sands of time. An unknown writer said, *“Footprints on the sands of time are never made by sitting down.”*

While their contributions may not have been as publicly recognized as the ones I have just mentioned there have been many people who have served the Lord and left an indelible mark upon hundreds if not thousands of lives in this very church!

- Pastors...
- Board members...
- Staff members...
- Sunday school teachers...
- Choir members...
- Ushers...
- Greeters...
- Bus drivers...

While some people are not necessarily in the public view their contributions are none the less important and not any less impacting.

In my opinion, Nehemiah is one of the great standout characters in the Bible whose footprints have been left deep and distinct on the path of the past. In fact, his footprints have inspired with fresh courage many

hearts who are suffering from illness and fatigue in the service of the Lord. (Story of the guy who quit his job because of illness and fatigue... He was sick and tired of working!)

Nehemiah's journey from Babylon to Jerusalem occupied three months. Think of this, a three-month survey of the costly journey ahead! Contrary to public opinion, not every thing happens over night! An English proverb aptly said, *"Rome was not built in a day."*

The journey to be where we are today in the ministries and forward vision of Christian Temple is a path which is decades long. *The path of the past is strewn with:* **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Success and failure...
- Giving and planning...
- Effort and resources...
- Hard work and tremendous effort...
- Sacrifice and wise investment...
- Careful attention to the will of God...

Because of the sacrifices and investments of the past this church is standing on the precipice of a challenging but rewarding future of expansion and growth for the Kingdoms sake. These are truly exciting times and we should embrace this moment with sobered reality, and excited confidence.

Over the next few weeks I would like to use the Old Testament stand out character, Nehemiah, to help us

understand how to forge our way successfully into the future.

Nehemiah was a man of prayer who placed the following things on his prayer list: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- For God to forgive his and Israel's sin...
- For God to prepare the heart of Artaxerxes the King of Babylon to allow him to go to Jerusalem to rebuild the walls of the city...
- For the assurance of the King for safe passage to Jerusalem...
- For provisions of timber from the forests, and stones from the quarries, that the city might be rebuilt...

All of Nehemiah's requests are answered by the Lord and Nehemiah is now on the long coveted field of labor. Once on his field of labor Nehemiah faces many challenges and takes the following actions: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- He took time for reflection...
- He surveyed the difficulties...
- He appealed for workers...
- He faces down the opposition...
- He achieves his dream...

I. NEHEMIAH TOOK TIME FOR REFLECTION...

Nehemiah 2:11 (NKJV) *"So I came to Jerusalem, and was there three days..."* Even though Nehemiah had previously visited the city to survey its need, upon

arrival, he takes an additional three days for reflection before proceeding.

I think it is also significant that Ezra waited three days after arriving in Jerusalem, before beginning the work that God had called him to do, Ezra 8:32. We do not have to look far into the Word of God to see that **the third day was very significant: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- On the third day of creation, God made trees, grass, fruit and vegetation...
- On the third day if the sacrifice had not been completely consumed, what was left was considered to be contaminated and must be discarded... Leviticus 7:18
- On the third day the sacrifice was to be returned to the person who made the sacrifice...
Abraham and Isaac Genesis 22 - Matthew 19:29
- Matthew 16:25
- On the third day the Lord promised to clear the name of His people... Joseph's prediction of the restoration of the Kings butler to his position
- Genesis 40:13
- On the third day the Lord promised to speak to the people... Exodus 19:9-11 (NKJV) ***"Then the LORD said to Moses, "I am going to come to you in a thick cloud so the people themselves can hear me as I speak to you. Then they will always have confidence in you. "Moses told the LORD what the people had said. 10 Then the LORD told Moses, "Go down and prepare the people for my visit. Purify them today and tomorrow, and have them wash their clothing.***

11 Be sure they are ready on the third day, for I will come down upon Mount Sinai as all the people watch."

- On the third day God provided water for the people... Exodus 15 - When the people traveled away from the Red Sea they were traveling without water and God provided water on the third day - Moses cast a tree into the bitter water of Marah and it became sweet - This happened on the third day
- On the third day the vision of the Children of Israel to inherit the Promised Land became reality... Joshua 1:11 (NKJV) ***"Go through the camp and tell the people to get their provisions ready. In three days you will cross the Jordan River and take possession of the land the LORD your God has given you."***
- On the third day God promises to give victory over our enemies... When the two spies were hiding in the house of Rahab, God promised to give them safe passage on the third day - Listen to the words of Rahab - Joshua 2:16 & 22 (NKJV) ***"Escape to the hill country," she told them. "Hide there for three days until the men who are searching for you have returned; then go on your way." The spies went up into the hill country and stayed there three days. The men who were chasing them had searched everywhere along the road, but they finally returned to the city without success."***
- On the third day God has promised to heal our bodies... Hezekiah - 2 Kings 20:5 (NKJV) ***"Go back to Hezekiah, the leader of my people. Tell***

him, 'This is what the LORD, the God of your ancestor David, says: I have heard your prayer and seen your tears. I will heal you, and three days from now you will get out of bed and go to the Temple of the LORD.'

- On the third day Jesus arose and all the third day promises find their fulfillment in him...

Even though, throughout the Word of God the third day is of great significance, possibly the greatest significance here is time for reflection, planning, and listening to the voice of God for determination of how Jerusalem could be properly reconstructed. The Word of God said, Isaiah 28:16 (KJV) ***"Therefore thus saith the Lord God, behold, I lay in Zion for a foundation a stone, a tried stone, a sure foundation: He that believeth shall not make haste."***

What significance does this have for us? Some people despise the past, and say that we should not waste our time reflecting upon it. To prove their point, they often use the Apostle Paul's words in Philippians 3:13-14 (NKJV) ***"Brethren, I do not count myself to have apprehended; but one thing I do, forgetting those things which are behind and reaching forward to those things which are ahead, (14) I press toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus."*** If we place Paul's words in proper context we soon discover he is saying that he is going to forget some things from the past because they were not conducive to pressing forward into the future. All of his failures needed to be forgotten, and some of his successes needed to be wiped from his memory as

well, so that he could forge into the future successfully.

While reflecting on the past should never become our dominant activity, there are some legitimate reasons to take the time to do so. I believe the time Ezra and Nehemiah set aside for reflection was a measured intentional game plan for the future of Jerusalem.

They were taking time for reflection for a number of reasons: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- They were remembering what Jerusalem had been, so that past mistakes were not repeated...
- They were remembering what Jerusalem had been, so that the good things could be repeated...
- They were remembering what Jerusalem had been, so that the renovation would transform the city into a better place than before...

I believe Ezra and Nehemiah emerged from their days of reflection with excitement and resolve for the success of the future of Jerusalem.

We have set aside the month of January to pray and reflect on how God has used the past to position Christian Temple to be a powerful force in this city for the future. We will emerge from these days excited and resolved to take the future on with new vitality and tenacity! **Though the past be glorious, I believe the future is even brighter!** (It's here for the taking!)

Please allow me to explain that there is not a person in this house today who appreciates the history of this great Church, and its leaders more than I do! I would be the first to admit that I am standing on the shoulders of all previous leaders to point to the future!

As we wade through the process of preparing for the work of the future we will need to reflect on the past from time to time because: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- We do not want to repeat the mistakes of the past...
- We want to repeat the successes of the past, with greater intensity...
- We want to make sure the future is more effective than the past...

One of the most difficult lessons we learn on this spiritual journey is to wait on God. Both Ezra and Nehemiah knew the value of this. They spent their time reflecting and praying to determine how they fit into Gods plan for Jerusalem, rather than how God fit into their plan for the city.

The plans we are making for the future have been years in the making and have been bathed in prayer, and we are excited that the Lord is allowing Christian Temple to be a part of building His Kingdom by: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Planting a satellite church in Pearland...
- Planting a Spanish speaking congregation in our present location...

- Building a Missions House for itinerating Missionaries on our present property...
- Expand our facilities through several expansion and improvement projects...

Some people would probably say that our goals are too industrious, but we make our plans in light of the fact that we serve a God who is capable of doing all things through those who walk in obedience to Him. Goals are to a church what oxygen is to a person. Benjamin Mays said, *“The tragedy in life doesn't lie in not reaching your goal. The tragedy lies in having no goal to reach.”*

Reaching goals take time, not everything can be accomplished in a short period of time. The accomplishment of certain goals often involve, a lifetime of work. All of the things we are dreaming of doing can certainly not be completed today or tomorrow, so we will be patient to work on Gods schedule. If we cannot wait on God we will get our cart before our horse and run the risk of sabotaging the will of God for this church. *This will all be accomplished on His timetable not ours!*

As we have discovered, three days are significant throughout the Bible but the most significant event to happen on the third day was the resurrection of Jesus. In Nehemiah's case, the three days were used to see their plans and purposes pass from death unto life, while they calmly waited before God!

Bro. Grant said, *“I’m convinced some people will make heaven, if they don’t run past the gate.”*

II. NEHEMIAH SURVEYS THE DIFFICULTIES...

Nehemiah 2:12-13 (NKJV) *“I arose in the night... neither told I any man what my God had put in my heart to do... and viewed the walls which were broken down”* Nehemiah, like a wise physician, begins by making a thorough diagnosis of the case.

Under the light of the moon and the stars, Nehemiah began to view the devastation of the city. What he discovers is the difficulty of dilapidated walls and heaps of rubbish. There was so much devastation and waste that he could not even ride his horse through the streets.

Many Christians live in a fool’s paradise because they refuse to believe there can be any difficulty, after all they are doing the will of God. After all, if we are doing the will of God shouldn’t everything be easy? Difficulties or the lack of them should never serve as an indicator of whether or not one is doing the will of God. Throughout the Word of God we encounter heroes of the faith doing the will of God in the face of the greatest of adversity: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Noah...
- The Three Hebrew Children...
- Daniel...
- Paul...

Jesus never promised an easy road to success. Samuel Johnson said, *“Nothing will ever be attempted if all possible objections must first be overcome.”*

Though Jesus never promised a journey devoid of difficulty He did say the person who counts the cost before building a house, will have what it takes to finish it! (Luke 14) Have you ever driven past a partially completed house or building which has obviously been abandoned? Several questions immediately come to mind: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Who started this building?
- Who does this property belong to?
- What is wrong with this building?
- Why did construction come to a halt?
- Will construction be resumed someday?
- What will this building look like when it is completed?

We can ill afford to chart the course for the future without weighing the cost of the journey. The cost of the destiny must be viewed in conjunction with the resources of the one who has ordained the dream. Someone said *“If God be our leader we should make our plans big.”*

Assessing the potential difficulty that lies between where we presently are and where we are going can certainly be a challenging task, unless, like Nehemiah, we know that God has placed everything necessary to succeed within our own hearts and hands. Isaiah 54:17

(NKJV) ***"No weapon formed against you shall prosper, And every tongue which rises against you in judgment You shall condemn. This is the heritage of the servants of the Lord, And their righteousness is from Me," Says the Lord.***" The word **"Formed"** in this verse literally means a plan crafted and created for your overthrow. The word **"Prosper"** means to be successful. In view of these facts, this Scripture can be paraphrased in this way: ***"No weapon crafted for your overthrow shall be successful."***

The promise of God to Joshua can also be claimed by all Christ followers. Joshua 1:5 (NKJV) ***"No man shall be able to stand before you all the days of your life; as I was with Moses, so I will be with you. I will not leave you nor forsake you."*** The assignment Joshua was attempting to carry out was to conquer and possess the Promised Land, which was occupied by giants! Many difficulties were strewn in the path ahead of Joshua but the promise of God was powerful on his behalf. Look at the fulfillment of this promise. Joshua 21:44 (NKJV) ***"The Lord gave them rest all around, according to all that He had sworn to their fathers. And not a man of all their enemies stood against them; the Lord delivered all their enemies into their hand."*** Joshua 23:9 (NKJV) ***"For the Lord has driven out from before you great and strong nations; but as for you, no one has been able to stand against you to this day."*** Even though we face difficulties, Joshua's promise is ours, just as the fulfillment of that promise belongs to us.

Someone said, *“The road to success is not straight. There is a curve called failure, a loop called confusion, speed bumps called friends, red lights called enemies, caution lights called family and flats called jobs. But, if you have a spare called determination, an engine called perseverance, insurance called faith, and a driver called Jesus, you will make it to a place called success.”*

Generations past have done their part to provide a full Gospel witness in this city, now it's our turn to do what must be done, my question is, are we up to the challenge?

I can assure you, it will not be easy street, there will be major difficulties, but in spite of it all God will be with us.

III. NEHEMIAH MAKES AN APPEAL FOR WORKERS...

Nehemiah 2:17 (NKJV) *“Then I said to them, “You see the distress that we are in,...Come and let us build the wall of Jerusalem, that we may no longer be a reproach.”* Some people seem to believe that the best way to accomplish a thing is to get someone else to do the work. They live by the philosophy, *“Here am I, Lord send Barney!”* Sam Ewing said, *“Hard work spotlights the character of people: some turn up their sleeves, some turn up their noses, and some don't turn up at all.”*

Please notice, Nehemiah did not say, *“Go and build,”* but *“Come, let us build.”*

Nehemiah was aware that the gargantuan work of restoring Jerusalem to its pristine glory and power could never be accomplished as long as: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- The leader single-handedly attempts to do all the work... The leader who feels the need to do everything himself will never be able to lead an organization very far.
- The leader believes he is too good to get his hands dirty... The leader who refuses to work alongside the laborers will never develop enough influence at the grass roots to be trusted or followed.
- The people refuse to be involved... The organization which embraces the philosophy of “*We hired a pastor and staff to do the work*” will never succeed because there is a limit to what a small group of hireling leaders can accomplish. In this scenario there is too many designated leaders and no followers.
- The people want to lead instead of follow... The organization that views their leaders, as hired guns will eventually implode. Power struggles will eat up enormous amounts of time and resources. Time that should be spent building will be invested in jockeying for position.

When I was a young child we used to sing a little song which simply said, “*If we all pull together, together, together, if we all pull together, how happy we’ll be. For your work is my work and our work is God’s*”

work, if we all pull together how happy we'll be."
Psalms 133:1 (NIV) ***"How good and pleasant it is
when brothers live together in unity!"***

If we are going to accomplish the work God has committed to us, it cannot be viewed as my work or your work; it must be viewed as the work of the Lord which we are all privileged to participate in. *It remains to be seen what God can do through a church which remains together in total unity over the long haul.* This is certainly one of the reasons Jesus prayed for us to become one in unity. John 17:23 (NIV)
"May they be brought to complete unity to let the world know that you sent me and have loved them even as you have loved me."

If you could grant the answer to the most important prayer request of your best friend, would you do it? Jesus is supposed to be the most important person in our life, and we have the power to answer His request; we should do it without regard to personal cost.

The work which had been committed to Nehemiah was more than just painting a Sunday school room or two; he was about to assume a major enterprise which would necessitate the commitment of leaders and the recruitment of an enormous number of workers and resources.

In order to do this successfully, he had to make sure every person was committed to the work before its inception! *Thomas Edison* said, *"Opportunity is*

missed by most people because it is dressed in overalls and looks like work.”

The devastation of the city was so severe that one could not ride a horse through the city without dismounting and continuing on foot. Nehemiah 2:13-14 (NLT) ***“After dark I went out through the Valley Gate, past the Jackal’s Well, and over to the Dung Gate to inspect the broken walls and burned gates. 14 Then I went to the Fountain Gate and to the King’s Pool, but my donkey couldn’t get through the rubble.”*** If a horse could not be ridden through the city can you imagine what kind of devastation was apparent for as far as the eye could see? It must have looked like New Orleans following the Katrina disaster. (PLAY A THREE MINUTE VIDEO OF THE KATRINA DISASTER)

Can you imagine attempting to clear this kind of rubble and committing to the work of rebuilding an entire city? Think about this, they did not have one piece of automated or heavy equipment available to them. The task which Nehemiah was facing was no small task. This would be rigorous, pain-staking, back-breaking work which would require an enormous amount of manpower and womanpower to see it through to its successful conclusion.

The work which God has committed to us will require each of us to become absolutely committed with our:
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Time...
- Talent...

- Effort...
- Prayers...
- Resources...

In order for Nehemiah and his followers to accomplish their assignment the philosophy which drove their organization must have been *“All at it, and always at it.”* This is a philosophy of everyone *“pulling together.”* Everyone would be called upon to contribute! Colossians 3: 11-14 (Message) *“ Words like Jewish and non-Jewish, religious and irreligious, insider and outsider, uncivilized and uncouth, slave and free, mean nothing. From now on everyone is defined by Christ, everyone is included in Christ. So, chosen by God for this new life of love, dress in the wardrobe God picked out for you: compassion, kindness, humility, quiet strength, discipline. Be even-tempered, content with second place, quick to forgive an offense. Forgive as quickly and completely as the Master forgave you. And regardless of what else you put on, wear love. It's your basic, all-purpose garment. Never be without it. Let the peace of Christ keep you in tune with each other, in step with each other. None of this going off and doing your own thing.”*

A common need should lead to unity of faith, which should lead to unity of effort. As the city of Jerusalem lying in ruin was a dishonor to every Jew, so *a Church that does not have vision for the future is a dishonor to each individual member.* Proverbs 29:18 (KJV)
“Where there is no vision, the people perish.”

The way to roll away the reproach is to arise and build, laying the displaced stones into their proper place until the work is finished. Everyone stays on the wall until the assignment is completed.

The task we have been assigned is no easy task, but if everyone will do their part each day, the work will soon become a success. What constitutes success? Success is your dreams with work clothes on.

Robert Byrne said, *"The purpose of life is a life of purpose."*

IV. NEHEMIAH MEETS WITH OPPOSITION...

Nehemiah 2:10, 19 (NKJV) ***"When Sanballat the Horonite and Tobiah the Ammonite official heard of it, they were deeply disturbed that a man had come to seek the well-being of the children of Israel. (19) But when Sanballat the Horonite, Tobiah the Ammonite official, and Geshem the Arab heard of it, they laughed at us and despised us, and said, "What is this thing that you are doing? Will you rebel against the king?"***

Nehemiah 4:1-3 (NKJV) ***"But it so happened, when Sanballat heard that we were rebuilding the wall, that he was furious and very indignant, and mocked the Jews. (2) And he spoke before his brethren and the army of Samaria, and said, "What are these feeble Jews doing? Will they fortify themselves? Will they offer sacrifices? Will they complete it in a day? Will they revive the stones from the heaps of***

“rubbish--stones that are burned?” (3) Now Tobiah the Ammonite was beside him, and he said, “Whatever they build, if even a fox goes up on it, he will break down their stone wall.”

It is interesting to me that those who stood in opposition to Nehemiah were not even on the radar screen as long as Jerusalem was laying in ruin.

Notice several **facts about opposition: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- The initiation of opposition usually begins with people setting around talking about things they do not have a clue about... It is obvious that Sanballat, Tobiah and Geshem had been caucusing with regard to what the Jews were doing, all this without even consulting with Nehemiah who was the architect of the plan.
- The motivation for opposition rarely makes good sense... Why oppose a man who is attempting to restore a city? Of course they use their defense of the King as their motivation. They couldn't have cared less about the King, they were afraid their positions might be threatened.
- Opposition always asks rhetorical questions which are accompanied by answers that are skewed with half-truths... The questions they were asking, were never intended to be answered they were intended to create doubt in the minds of Nehemiah's helpers.
- The nature of opposition is always rebellion; therefore those who are involved usually turn

bitter... Sanballat, Tobiah and Geshem began this tirade by talking among themselves; their actions turned to rhetorical questions; which led to false assumptions couched in bitterness. Look at it, *“If a fox runs across their stone wall, he will break it down.”* Hogwash!

The more closely you try to follow the will of God, the bitterer the opposition will become. This should not come as such a surprise to us, the world and the Church hated Jesus without a cause, and the disciple is not greater than his Lord. Matthew 10:24 (NKJV) *“A disciple is not above his teacher, nor a servant above his master.”*

Everyone stands to benefit from a city being restored. The benefits include: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Improved housing...
- Improved living conditions...
- Improved educational system...
- Improved infrastructure, streets etc...
- Improved opportunities for making a living...

When you think about it they have everything to gain and nothing to lose, yet they become opposition to the will of God. What is not to like here? The opposition can rarely give you a good reason why they oppose a thing. They are usually in opposition because it just doesn't fit their style. This is never a good enough reason to stick our feet in the sand in an effort to slow progress.

There are actually two unpardonable sins with human beings: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Failure...
- Success...

Sadly the staunchest opposition to the plans of the church almost never come from outside sources, but from within.

Nehemiah's opposition made a fatal mistake which is often made in a spiritual venue, they failed to recognize that this was not Nehemiah's work, it was God's work! The opposition oftentimes underestimates the level at which the directive originated.

In the book of Acts, the Apostles had been imprisoned and very directly communicated with concerning the will of the religious hierarchy, that they were not to preach Jesus any further. By a miracle of God they were released and they immediately returned to the very place they were arrested and continued to proclaim the Gospel. They were brought before the Council, and in the process of being interrogated, a man on the Council sensed a mistake might be in the making and he says the following. Acts 5:34-39 (NLT) ***"But one member had a different perspective. He was a Pharisee named Gamaliel, who was an expert on religious law and was very popular with the people. He stood up and ordered that the apostles be sent outside the council chamber for a while. (35) Then he addressed his colleagues as follows: "Men of Israel, take care what you are planning to do to***

these men! (36) *Some time ago there was that fellow Theudas, who pretended to be someone great. About four hundred others joined him, but he was killed, and his followers went their various ways. The whole movement came to nothing.* (37) *After him, at the time of the census, there was Judas of Galilee. He got some people to follow him, but he was killed, too, and all his followers were scattered.* (38) *"So my advice is, leave these men alone. If they are teaching and doing these things merely on their own, it will soon be overthrown.* (39) *But if it is of God, you will not be able to stop them. You may even find yourselves fighting against God."* Sometimes the wisdom of the world exceeds that of those that are in the household of faith.

Opposing Gods agenda is an unhealthy business. (Michael's assessment of David's dancing – She was barren for the rest of her life – I wonder how many barren people and preachers are in our churches and do not even understand the reason for their barrenness is because they opposed Gods plan? All she did was to be a little bit critical of his experience.)

One of the most damaging consequences of opposition for those in leadership is the introduction of doubt.

Arthur Golden said, *"A mind troubled by doubt cannot focus on the course to victory."* Many great leaders have failed to move their organization forward because key people spoke doubt into their life, rather than encouragement.

I have discovered that if I am in opposition to a thing, oftentimes the best course of action is to take a wait and see approach.

Nehemiah's opposition would rather have a city in ruin, than to lose their place of control! Some people are determined to either rule or ruin a Church, and the sad fact is they usually wind up doing both!

Have you ever wondered why a person would not want to provide a better worship place for their descendants? It escapes me, why they would not want to do everything in their power to make sure their church had every available tool to reach a city? (Ruth Burris)

Why would a person want to oppose the progress of a Church, rather than support it?

There are **three things that cause people to criticize:**
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Ignorance...
- Jealousy...
- Inferiority complex...

God desires for His people to move forward in one accord. **Look what happened in the First Century Church that was in one accord:** **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- 3,000 saved the first day... (Acts 2:37-38)
- God added to the church daily such as should be saved... (Acts 2:47)

- 2,000 are saved at Solomon's Porch... (Acts 3:1-4)
- The Samaritans become Christians... (Acts 8:1-12)
- Men and women were baptized following their conversion... (Acts 8:12-13)
- The Ethiopian eunuch is converted... (Acts 8:36-39)
- Saul (Paul) receives Christ... (Acts 9:18)
- The household of Cornelius becomes Christians... (Acts 10:43)
- The people of Antioch are converted... (Acts 11:19-21)
- Sergius Paulus becomes a Christian on the island of Paphos... (Acts 13:4-12)
- Many Jews and religious proselytes follow Paul and Barnabas at Antioch in Pisidia... (Acts 13:13-48)
- A great multitude of individuals follow Christ at Iconium... (Acts 14:1)
- An undetermined number of people make decisions for Christ at Lystra and Derbe... (Acts 14)
- The Philippian jailer and his family become followers of Christ... (Acts 16)
- Lydia comes to faith in Christ... (Acts 16)
- A great multitude of the Greeks and many of the leading women join themselves to the faith at Thessalonica... (Acts 17:1-12)
- The conversion of the Athenians at Mars Hill... (Acts 17:16-34)

- Many Corinthian people are converted... (Acts 18:8)
- At Corinth Aquila and his wife Pricilla follow Jesus... (Acts 18:24-28)
- The twelve disciples of John the Baptist are converted... (Acts 19:1-10)

Hannibal Smith on the show the “A Team” used to say, *“I love it when a plan comes together.”* When we participate in Gods plan for the earth, we will love to be a part of what happens when His plan comes together. When this happens, He makes the ones of us who are the most ignorant, look brilliant!

Are we ready to step out in faith and become wall builders rather than the critical crowd who pickets the building of a wall?

Sidney Greenberg said, *“A successful man is one who can lay a firm foundation with the bricks that others throw at him.”*

V. NEHEMIAH ACHIEVS HIS DREAM...

Nehemiah faced the scoffers’ opposition with a simple, brief, fearless statement of faith in God. Nehemiah 2:20 (NKJV) ***“The God of heaven Himself will prosper us.”*** Notice, Nehemiah never placed his trust in man; he placed his trust in Gods ability to empower them to carry the plan of God to a successful conclusion, using them to accomplish His will.

No God given destiny can be attained without exercising complete faith in God. Hebrews 11:6

(KJV) **“But without faith it is impossible to please Him; for he that cometh to God must believe that he is, and that He is a rewarder of them that diligently seek Him.”**

Nehemiah knew better than to try to face the opposition on his own! We cannot expect to emerge from this expedition with victory, if we lean on the arm of flesh. **Proverbs 3:5-6: (NKJV) “Trust in the Lord with all your heart, And lean not on your own understanding; (6) In all your ways acknowledge Him, And He shall direct your paths.”**

- Trust - Be bold and secure, have confidence.
- Heart - Pouring everything we have into the work of God.
- Lean - To lean on, to trust in. (Use illustration of having someone stand behind me, and lean on them in such a way that if they move I fall...)
- Understanding - Discernment or intuition.
- Ways - Road or journey, course of life.
- Acknowledge - To know or to recognize.
- Direct - Upright or pleasing.
- Path - Way of living.

The Don Nordin Paraphrase on this Scripture looks like this: ***“If you place your confidence in the Lord, your security will come from Him as well. Place your heart, mind and soul into doing His will, pouring yourself into His purposes. Do not trust in your own discernment or intuition. In the course of life know and recognize God and he will cause you to be upright and pleased with your way of living.”***

In saying “*The God of heaven will prosper us,*”
Nehemiah is saying this is the work of the living,
faithful, almighty God of Heaven: **(PLACE ON THE
SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- He is for it...
- He is with it...
- He is in it...
- He will make it successful...

A radio preacher by the name of Brother Ike, who was
from a by-gone generation used to say, “*You can’t lose
with the stuff I use.*”

Doing the work of God is really not at all complicated
or difficult; all we must do is to establish whether this
is our work or God’s work. Once we determine what
we are attempting to do is the work of God, all we
have to do, is to do His work according to His
instructions.

Nehemiah also declares the truth about himself and his
co-workers. Nehemiah 2:20 (NKJV) “*The God of
heaven will prosper us, Therefore we, His servants,
will arise and build.*” Nehemiah is saying: **(PLACE
ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- We are His servants...
- We are doing His business...
- We will go on...
- We are prepared for His work...
- We will succeed...

Romans 8:31 (KJV) ***“If God be for us, who can be against us?”***

Finally Nehemiah declares the truth about his enemies:
Nehemiah 2:20 (NKJV) ***“You have no heritage or right or memorial in Jerusalem.”*** **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- You are strangers to God...
- You are not His people...
- There is nothing which belongs to you in this city...
- You have no right to any of its privileges...
- The Work we are doing obviously awakens no sacred memories in you...
- The work here is none of your business...

Nehemiah gave his opposition a tongue lashing and never allowed their insults and threats to cause him to break his stride. God desires for us to take the same approach toward those who would seek to hinder and oppose His purpose for our lives.

Because of the stiff opposition, Nehemiah finally put a weapon in one hand of his workmen, and a tool in the other. Nehemiah 4:18 (NKJV) ***“Every one of the builders had his sword girded at his side as he built. And the one who sounded the trumpet was beside me.”*** (Put a tool pouch on one side and a sword on the other... Have someone in the congregation blow revelry on the trumpet at the appropriate time)

He took drastic measures to insure the success of the work. He prepared for the work. Even though God

was helping them they had to do their part in preparation for the work.

Nehemiah 6:15 (NIV) “***So the wall was completed, in fifty-two days.***” Nehemiah 7:1 (NIV) “***After the wall had been rebuilt and I had set the doors in place, the gatekeepers and the singers and the Levites were appointed.***”

Do we have a heart to do the work? Only time will reveal the real truth because our attitude and aptitude will be proven through our actions over the long haul.

Sir Winston Churchill said, “*Success is never final. Failure is never fatal. Courage is what counts.*”

Nehemiah finished his work and we will finish ours!